

Lost track: The last three years have been disappointing by any measure for Johannes Vetter. GETTY IMAGES



Vetter late than never

On a comeback trail, the javelin thrower reflects on a **difficult past** riddled with injuries and missed competitions, while prioritising his Olympic dreams over the world record.

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When he sat down for a *Zoom* interview with *Sportstar*, Johannes Vetter chose a spot just in front of his trophy case at his apartment in Offenburg, Germany. It's a cabinet filled with memories from a career that has marked him as one of the most fearsome competitors in javelin throw for many years. Besides mementos from his many victories at the European championships and a statue of a spearman from a competition in Germany, there are

also multiple Diamond League trophies as well as medals from the 2019 World championships where he won bronze and the one in 2017 where he won gold.

There's not much from more recent competitions, though. For all his ability — he has the second-best throw in history (97.76m) and has more throws over 90m than anyone else in history — the last three years have been disappointing by any measure for Vetter. A massive favourite for gold at the Tokyo Games, Vetter finished a disappointing ninth in a competition

where India's Neeraj Chopra created history to win gold. That was followed by a mystery injury to his throwing shoulder at the start of 2022. He threw only twice that year. Last year, as this injury persisted, he competed just four times, with a best effort of 80.82m.

Vetter, still, tried to keep a positive outlook. A look at his social media profile all through that dry spell has him posting pictures and videos of himself in the weight room and training hall. Yet there are times when the German admits to being frustrated with it all. This was